the *Srimad Bhagavatam*, or *Bhagavata Purana*, focusing on the life and times of Lord Krishna, is still recited in temples and homes across India.

The *Purana*s mark a significant development in Hinduism, with a much greater emphasis on the worship of Gods in human form, unlike the earlier Vedic faith; where the latter had relied on rituals and sacrifices in which *homam*s (prayer rituals around a fire), usually involving the fire god Agni, played a major role, the Puranic practice principally involved idol-worship and *puja*s. (It is suggested that while the Vedic era saw only the worship of a formless and imageless God, the conduct of rituals and the propitiation of the river and mountain and tree gods of local tribes—all of which were 'portable' and not confined to a fixed spot—it was the arrival of the Greeks under Alexander in the fourth century BCE that brought into India the idea of permanent temples enshrining stone images of heroes and gods.) Again, while the Hinduism of the Vedas emerged from mantras and rituals, including elaborate sacrifices, the *Purana*s promoted their values entirely on the basis of myths and stories. By developing the concept of the saguna Brahman to go with the exalted idea of the nirguna Brahman, the Puranic faith integrated the Vedic religion into the daily worship of ordinary people. Using the seductive power of *maya* (illusion), the *nirguna* Brahman of the Vedas took the form of *saguna* Brahman or Ishvara, the creator of *prakriti*, the natural world and the God or Bhagavan of all human beings. Vishnu and Shiva were recognised as Ishvaras; the followers of the former, the Vaishnavas, worshipped Him in several *avatar*s, while the followers of Shiva, the Shaivites, confined their worship to Shiva alone, though in several aspects (the dancing Nataraja, the powerfully symbolic *lingam*), and his immediate family (his consort Parvati, his sons Ganesh or Vinayaka, and Skanda or Murugan). Puranic Hinduism witnessed the absorption (even 'Sanskritisation') of the existing local cultures and the adoption of their deities and heroes into Hindu mythology; it is in the Puranic age that both Vaishnavites and Shaivites accepted idol worship, which was earlier absent from the Vedic faith. The *Purana*s offered a bridge between the Vedic religion and local folkways, between highbrow philosophers and vernacular cultures, assimilating both in a narrative of inclusive ethics. It